

Ada Johnson-Kanu

Assistant Professor · Department of Political Science · University of Kentucky

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Academic Positions

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science, University of Kentucky

2022 – present

Affiliate faculty: African and African American Studies, Commonwealth Institute for Black Studies, International Studies

Education

Ph.D. Political Science, University of California, Merced

2021

Dissertation: Colonial Legacies in State Building: Bureaucratic Embeddedness, Public Goods Provision, and Public Opinion in Nigeria

► Best Dissertation on Race and Ethnic Politics 2022, REP Section, APSA

M.A. Economics, University of Akron

2014

B.A. Economics, University of Akron

2012

Research Fields

Comparative politics, political economy of development

Book Projects

Sharing the National Cake: Ethnic Representation and Competition in the Nigerian Federal Civil Service

Manuscript in progress

Peer-Reviewed Publications

de Kadt, Daniel, Ada Johnson-Kanu, and Melissa Sands (2024). “[State Violence, Party Formation, and Electoral Accountability: The political legacy of the Marikana massacre.](#)” *American Political Science Review*, 118(2), 563–583.

[[Lead article](#)]

Working Papers

Do Elections Improve Service Delivery? Evidence from Local Governments in Nigeria (with Nick Cruz)

The Effects of Fuel Subsidy Removal on Nigerian Households.

Precolonial States and Development: Evidence from Agriculture in Africa (with Aditya Dasgupta)

The Man Leopard Murders and Contemporary Trust in the Nigerian Police (with Godwin Okore*)

Colonial Treaties in British West Africa

*Indicates graduate student co-author.

Other Publications

Johnson-Kanu, Ada. Book review of *Electoral Commissions and Democratization in Africa: Everyday Production of Democratic Legitimacy* by Nicholas Kerr. *Africa Spectrum*. 2026.

Johnson-Kanu, Ada. Historical Origins of Ethnic Representation in the Nigerian Bureaucracy. *Broadstreet blog*. 2022.

Johnson-Kanu, Ada. Origins and Consequences of Descriptive Representation in the Nigerian Civil Service. *APSA Comparative Politics Newsletter*. Fall 2021.

Grossman, Shelby, Sean Gallagher, Ada Johnson-Kanu, Nicole Wilson, and David Thiel. #ZakzakyLifeMatters: An Investigation into a Facebook Operation Linked to the Islamic Movement in Nigeria (TAKEDOWN). *Stanford Internet Observatory*. 2020.

Awards

Best Dissertation Award, APSA Race and Ethnic Politics section	2022
Department Teaching Award, UC Merced	Summer 2019

Teaching Experience

University of Kentucky

Introduction to Comparative Politics	S2024, S2025, F2025, S2026
African Politics (UG)	S2024, S2025
African Politics (G)	S2026
Political Economy (G)	S2023
Comparative Politics Seminar (G)	F2023, F2025

University of California, Merced

<i>Instructor of Record:</i>	Su2020
African Politics (UG)	

Teaching Assistant:

Introduction to Comparative Politics (UG)	F2016
Introduction to International Relations (UG)	S2018, F2020
Introduction to American Politics (UG)	F2019
Statistical Inference (UG)	F2017
Intermediate Macroeconomics, Economics (UG)	Su2017, F2018

Invited Talks & Workshops

Category, Hierarchy, and Cooperation Workshop, Santa Fe Institute	Spring 2025
University of Wisconsin–Madison, Comparative Politics/Political Economy Colloquium	Spring 2023

Conferences & Workshops

2026 Midwest Political Science Association (Presenter, Discussant, Scheduled)

2025 Virtual Historical Political Economy Workshop (Presenter), American Political Science Association (Presenter, Discussant), Southern Workshop on Empirical Political Science (SoWEPS) (Panel Chair), Midwest Political Science Association (Presenter, Discussant)

2024 SoWEPS (Panel Chair).

2023 American Political Science Association (Presenter), Summer Institute on Public Sector Organizational Effectiveness, Midwest Political Science Association (Presenter, Discussant), Kentucky Political Science Association (Presenter, Discussant)

2021 American Political Science Association (Presenter), Working Group in African Political Economy (WGAPE) (Presenter), Virtual Historical Political Economy Workshop (Presenter, Discussant), Minority Politics Online Seminar Series (MPOSS) (Presenter).

2020 American Political Science Association (Presenter), Midwest Political Science Association (canceled due to COVID-19), Western Political Science Association (canceled due to COVID-19), CA Working Group in African Political Economy (WGAPE) (Presenter), African Politics Conference Group (APCG) Online Colloquium (Presenter), University of California Africanists' Workshop.

2019 Midwest Political Science Association (Presenter, Discussant).

Service to Department

Organizer

African Politics Reading/Research Group 2025 – present

Advising — University of Kentucky

Faith Awah, Dissertation Committee member 2026 – present

Al Amin MD, Dissertation Committee member 2026 – present

Hannah Cake, Dissertation Committee member 2024 – present

Benjamin Leo, Dissertation Committee member 2024 – 2025

Sullivan Edeani, subfield advisor Fall 2025

Obaloluwa Aka, subfield advisor Fall 2023

Committees — University of Kentucky

Department of Political Science Graduate Committee 2023 – present

Chair, Comparative Politics Comprehensive Exam Committee Fall 2023

Department of Political Science DEI Committee 2022 – 2023

Service to Discipline

APSA Annual Conference, African Politics Section Co-Chair 2026

SoWEPS 8 Co-Convener Spring 2025

MPSA Annual Conference, Economic Development Section Chair 2025

ASA Best Paper Published in ASR, Awards Committee 2024

APSA Mancur Olson Best Dissertation in Political Economy, Awards Committee member 2024

APCG Online Colloquium, Co-Organizer 2023 – 2026

Reviewer: *American Journal of Political Science, American Political Science Review (3×), Africa Spectrum (2×), African Studies Review, National Science Foundation*

Field Work

Nigeria (2019, 2021, 2023)

Technology & Skills

Cloud Vision API, Git, Google Earth Engine, L^AT_EX, QGIS, Python, R

Languages

Hausa (Intermediate), Igbo (Native)